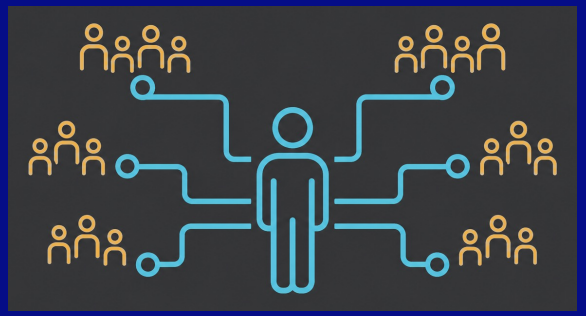


DHUM101
Socially Responsible Computing

University of Otago
ŌTĀKOU WHAKAIHU WAKA
Te Kura Rorohiko
School of Computing
Te Reo Inarahi me te Mātai Wetereo
English and Linguistics

Lecture 2
Drivers and strategies of the tech industry

- Stephen Cranefield
Semester 2, 2026

Your class representatives

Thanks to the following students for volunteering to be your class representatives.

- Sarah Al-Shanfari
  alsmo131@student.otago.ac.nz
- Liam Young
  youli404@student.otago.ac.nz

They are also listed in the Essentials section of the Aoroa site.

Advertisements





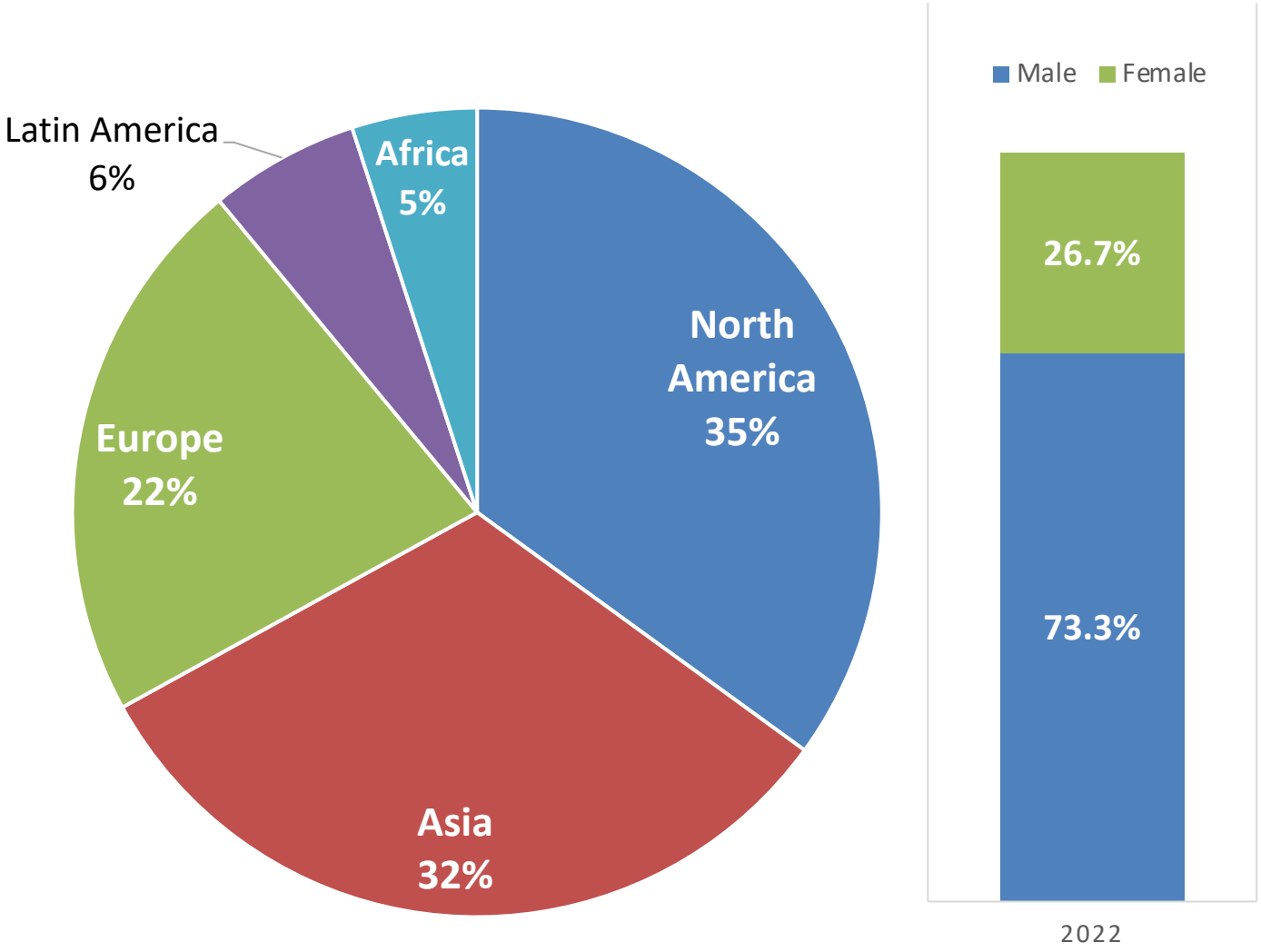
Overview

- Tech Industry Demographics, Culture , Leadership and Ideology.
- Big Tech and Politics
- Tech industry business models and strategies
- Takeaway message

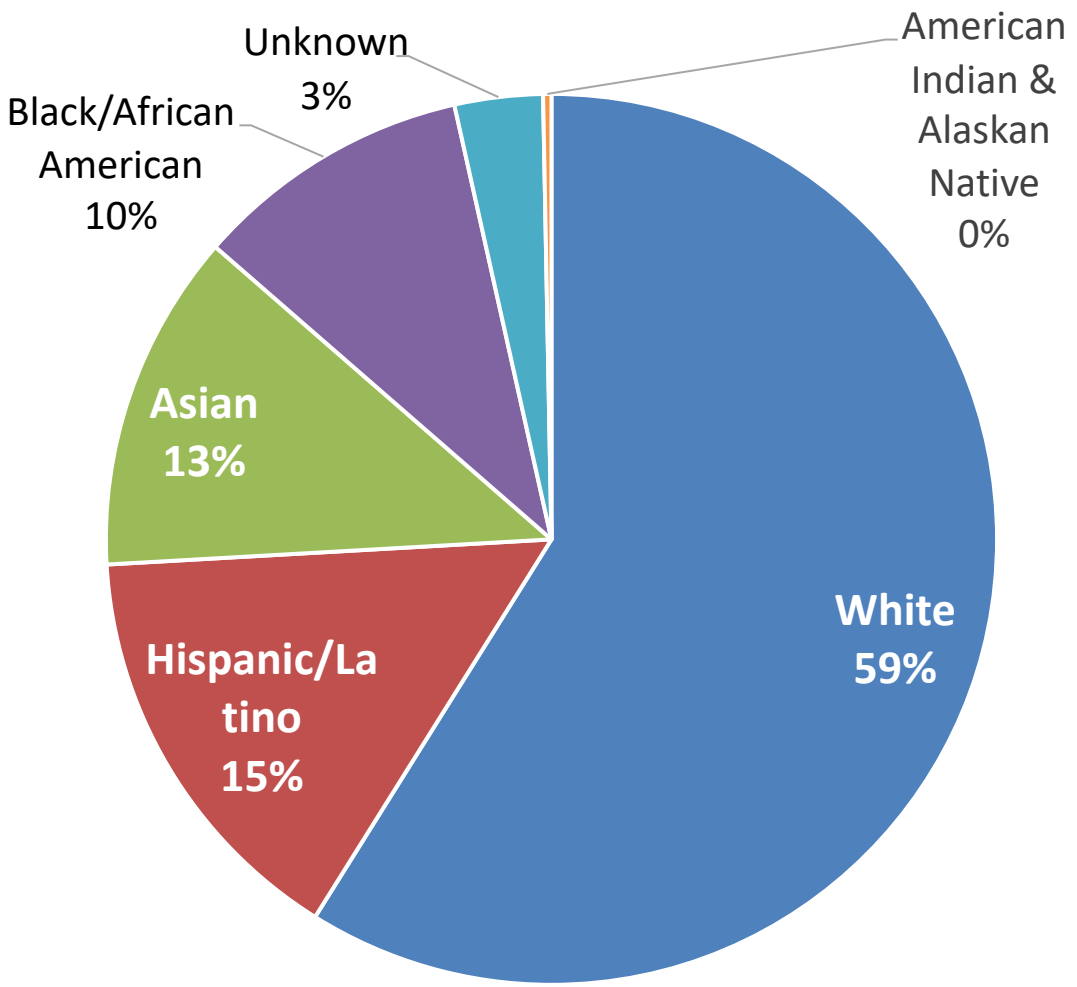
Tech Industry Demographics, Culture , Leadership and Ideology

Demographics

Global Tech Industry Distribution



Race and Ethnicity (US)



Redrawn from https://www.zippia.com/advice/tech-industry-statistics/, Zippia.com. "Last Modified and Fact Checked on: Jan. 20, 2026"

Tech Bros and broligarchs

"The term *Tech Bro* typically refers to a stereotype within the technology industry, often depicting a young, usually white, affluent, and confident male .... often associated with Silicon Valley and startup culture, where traits like risk-taking and a focus on disruption are celebrated. However, the term can also carry negative connotations due to the perpetuation of systemic inequalities and exclusionary practices within the tech industry."

https://yourstory.com/2024/05/tech-bro-mindset-culture-decoded

"The *broligarchy* is a term that refers to the rich, well-connected tech bros now flexing real power inside the Trump administration - CEOs like Meta's Mark Zuckerberg, Sundar Pichai of Google ... and others like Jeff Bezos and ... Elon Musk. It's clear that these broligarchs have enormous influence not just in tech, but now in politics".

Don Gonyea, quoted at
https://www.npr.org/2025/05/03/nx-s1-5379951/what-is-the-broligarchy

Some US broligarchs



AI-generated image. Source: https://knowyourmeme.com/memes/tech-ceos-standing-in-a-parking-lot

Historical analogy

"*Robber Baron* was a term applied to a businessman in the 19th century who engaged in unethical and monopolistic practices, utilized corrupt political influence, faced almost no business regulation, and amassed enormous wealth."
https://www.thoughtco.com/robber-baron-definition-1773342

Is this a good metaphor for poorly treated Amazon warehouse and Tesla factory workers, social media addicts with their attention saturated, gig economy workers managed by algorithms, PTSD-suffering social media content moderators, and low-paid data-labellers for AI training?



Bernhard Gillam, "The protectors of our industries", 1883
https://loc.gov/pictures/resource/ds.16881/

However, to be fair ...

"The overweening self-righteousness of the most voluble tycoons has discredited the idea that messianic innovators can possibly be well-intentioned. But there is no necessary connection between making a fortune in the Valley and egomania unbound, and nor is it fair to paint the technology sector as a bastion of anarcho-libertarianism. **For every Donald Trump supporter in the tech industry, there are multiple progressives. For every avaricious egotist, there is also a Bill Gates, who has dedicated much of his Microsoft fortune to improving the life expectancy of the world's poorest.**"

Sebastian Mallaby, The Infinity Machine, 2026, Penguin Press, 2026

The “move fast and break things” culture



But maybe not Software Engineer!

- "We have a saying: "Move fast and break things." The idea is that if you never break anything, you're probably not moving fast enough.” - Mark Zuckerberg, Facebook CEO, February 2012
- “The principle: shipping speed matters more than avoiding occasional production bugs because (a) competitors are also moving fast, and (b) most bugs can be fixed faster than competitive advantages can be regained.” https://virconlegal.com/term/move-fast-and-break-things/
- However, critics have argued that this motto was also seen as a licence to ignore societal impacts.
- Many start-up companies in Silicon Valley followed the same approach to accelerate innovation and gain market share.

Source: https://xkcd.com/1428/. Licence: CC BY-NC 2.5

An assortment of Silicon Valley ideologies

What motivates Silicon Valley tech leaders? Profit and competitive advantage, but also a host of inter-related ideologies. Examples from https://polymathic.usc.edu/silicon-valley-isms-terminology-and-readings:

- Technological Utopianism: "technological progress will inevitably produce a utopian or near-perfect society".
- Technological Determinism: "technological development drives historical change, shaping social structures, cultural values, and human behavior in a largely linear and inevitable way"
- Techno-libertarianism: "technology, and especially digital networks, can empower individuals, bypass centralized authority, and create decentralized systems that promote autonomy, innovation, and resistance to state control""
- Transhumanism: This "envisions humanity transcending its biological roots by replacing frail bodies and finite minds with synthetic organs, neural implants, and ultimately, digital consciousness."
- Accelerationism: "advocates speeding up technological and market processes to bring about radical transformation or rupture"
- Longtermism: "the most important moral priority is safeguarding the far future, given the overwhelming number of potential future lives that could exist"
- Singularitarianism: "The belief in the near-term ... point at which artificial intelligence surpasses human intelligence and begins to improve itself ... ushering in a post-human era marked by rapid advances in cognition, longevity, and societal reorganization"

Three arguments against these ideologies

- “First, these ideas are reductive, in that they make all problems into problems about technology. All the ills of the world will be solved when the Singularity arrives, or when the superintelligent AI solves them for us, or when we go into space."
- "Second, these ideas are profitable, aligning nicely with the bottom line of the tech industry via the promise of perpetual growth. ..."
- "Third, and perhaps most importantly these ideas offer transcendence, allowing adherents to feel they can safely ignore all limitations. Go to space, and you can ignore scarcity of resources, not to mention legal restrictions. Be a longtermist, and you can ignore conventional morality, justifying whatever actions you take by claiming they're necessary to ensure the future safety of humanity. Hasten the Singularity, and you can ignore death itself, or at least assure yourself that you can put it off for a few billion years."

Quotes from Adam Becker, *More Everything Forever: AI overlords, space empires and Silicon Valley’s crusade to control the fate of humanity*, Basic Books, 2025

Disturbing quotes on transhumanism from some prominent voices

Reported by Émile P. Torres in “One Half a Pro-Human Manifesto” https://t.co/HhkURJj26J

Richard Sutton (2024 Turing Award winner):
While AI might “displace us from existence … we should not resist [this] succession … why shouldn’t those who are the smartest become powerful?”

Daniel Faggella (Entrepreneur):
“[T]he great (and ultimately, only) moral aim of artificial general intelligence” is to create our “worthy successor”, defined as “a posthuman intelligence so capable and morally valuable that you would gladly prefer that it (not humanity) control the government, and determine the future path of life itself.”

Jürgen Schmidhuber (German AI pioneer)
“in the long run, humans will not remain the crown of creation. … But that’s okay because there is still beauty, grandeur, and greatness in realizing that you are a tiny part of a much grander scheme which is leading the universe from lower complexity towards higher complexity.”

Eliezer Yudkowsky (US AI researcher & writer):
“[S]hould humans in their present form be around together? Are we, like, kind of too sad in some ways? … I’d say that the happy future looks like beings of light having lots of fun in a nicely connected computing fabric powered by the Sun, if we haven’t taken the sun apart yet.”

The Techno-Optimist Manifesto

An expression of accelerationism by Silicon Valley venture capitalist Marc Andressen. Some excerpts:

- Technology is the glory of human ambition and achievement, the spearhead of progress, and the realization of our potential.
- We believe technology is a *lever on the world* – the way to make more with less.
- We believe that there is no material problem – whether created by nature or by technology – that cannot be solved with more technology.
- We believe there is no conflict between capitalist profits and a social welfare system that protects the vulnerable.
- Combine technology and markets and you get … the techno-capital machine, the engine of perpetual material creation, growth, and abundance.
- We believe any deceleration of AI will cost lives. Deaths that were preventable by the AI that was prevented from existing is a form of murder.
- A technologically strong America is a force for good in a dangerous world.
- We believe technology is liberatory. Liberatory of human potential. Liberatory of the human soul, the human spirit. Expanding what it can mean to be free, to be fulfilled, to be alive.
- Our enemy is the Precautionary Principle, which would have prevented virtually all progress since man first harnessed fire.

https://a16z.com/the-techno-optimist-manifesto/

The race toward Artificial General Intelligence

- "The race toward Artificial General Intelligence (AGI) is driven by a dangerous and deeply flawed assumption: **that whoever reaches AGI first gains overwhelming power — and everyone else risks irrelevance or subjugation.** This creates a "winner-takes-all" incentive structure where speed is rewarded, caution is punished, and safety research becomes a strategic disadvantage. As a result, the default trajectory of AGI development is **reckless, unstable, and pointed toward predictable catastrophe**."

  From https://www.linkedin.com/pulse/reckless-trajectory-how-winner-takes-all-ai-threaten-global-trivedi-1opqc/
  Also see https://society5initiative.substack.com/p/is-the-agi-race-a-reckless-gamble

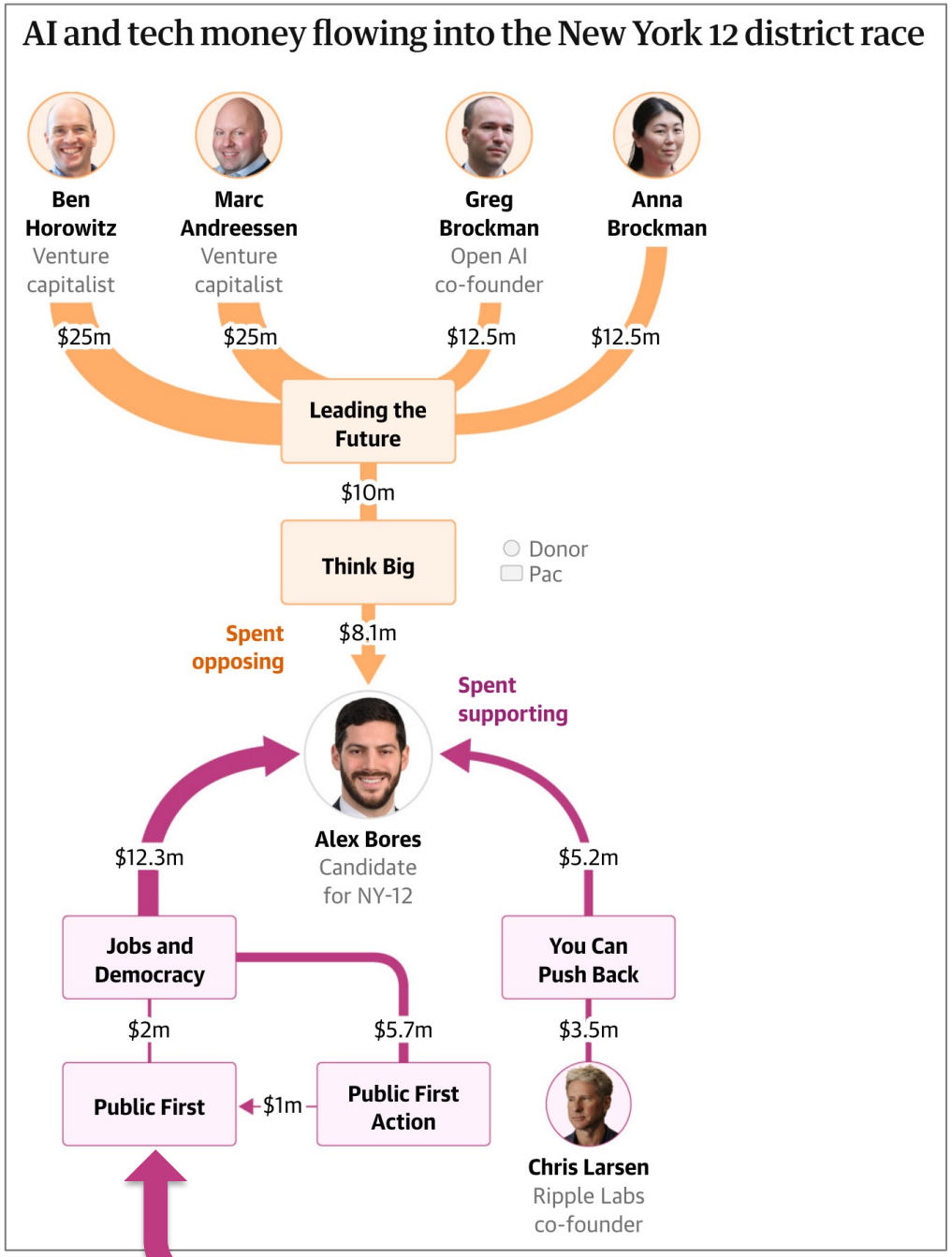


Image by ChatGPT

Big Tech and Politics (especially regarding AI)

Politics meets the broligarchs

- "The robber barons [in 19th Century USA] were famously philanthropists. Today's tech titans do get involved in philanthropy, but seem more interested in backing political campaigns or reshaping the government itself than signaling their generosity!"
  https://findhigherground.substack.com/p/a-taxonomy-of-the-broligarchs



AI regulation meets US politics

- **Middle:** Alex Bores
  - Introduced the Responsible AI Safety and Education Act to the New York State Assembly in 2025 and co-sponsored a bill to impose a one-year moratorium on data centres in NY in May 2026.
  - Running to be representative for a New York congressional district
- **Top:** Techno-optimist manifesto authors and an OpenAI co-founder and wife are funding US political action committees (so-called Super PACs) to back pro-AI candidates (and oppose Bores).
- **Bottom:** Funding in support of Bores (and AI regulation) from other Super PACs.

Guardian graphic. Data from US Federal Election Commission. Note: Includes donations over $1m as of 22 June 2026. Source: https://www.theguardian.com/us-news/2026/jun/22/new-york-city-house-primary-race Copied by University of Otago, 23/06/2026. Also, see https://techcrunch.com/2025/11/28/the-race-to-regulate-ai-has-sparked-a-federal-vs-state-showdown/



MENU

SEARCH

NEWS GALLERY LIVESTREAM TRUMP ACCOUNTS SAVE AMERICA INVES

FACT SHEETS

Fact Sheet: President Donald J. Trump Ensures a National Policy Framework for Artificial Intelligence

The White House | December 11, 2025

PREVENTING A PATCHWORK OF AI REGULATIONS: Today, President Donald J. Trump signed an Executive Order to protect American AI innovation from an inconsistent and costly compliance regime resulting from varying State laws.

- The Order directs the Attorney General to establish an AI Litigation Task Force to challenge unconstitutional, preempted, or otherwise unlawful State AI laws that harm innovation.
- The Order directs the Secretary of Commerce to publish an evaluation of State AI laws that conflict with national AI policy priorities and withhold non-deployment Broadband Equity Access and Deployment (BEAD) funding from any State with such AI laws. Other agencies are directed to consider whether to make an absence of similar laws, or a policy of enforcement discretion with respect to any existing such laws, a condition of applicable discretionary grant programs.
- The Order instructs the Federal Trade Commission and Federal Communications Commission to take actions that will limit States' ability to force AI companies to deceive consumers, including determining whether laws that force companies to embed DEI into their models cause those companies to violate the Federal Trade Commission Act, and considering whether to adopt a Federal reporting and disclosure standard for AI models.
- The Order calls for the development of a national AI legislative framework that would preempt State AI laws that stifle innovation.

STRENGTHENING AMERICAN COMPETITVENESS: President Trump is acting decisively to ensure our great technological pioneers can compete on the world stage, ensuring America's national security and economic prosperity in the age of AI.

AI regulation meets Geopolitics

- President Trump: "Investment in AI is helping to make the U.S. Economy the 'HOTTEST' in the World, but overregulation by the States is threatening to undermine this Major Growth 'Engine.'
- … We MUST have one Federal Standard instead of a patchwork of 50 State Regulatory Regimes. If we don't, then China will easily catch us in the AI race."

Tech industry business models and strategies

Platformisation

- Build and monetise a digital platform that acts as an intermediary between users and suppliers of goods or service(s).
- The platform owner sets the rules, controls access, collects and analyses data, and often captures a significant share of the proceeds from transactions on the platform.
- Examples: Amazon Marketplace, Uber, Airbnb, Apple, YouTube, Facebook, Instagram, TikTok and Android app stores.
- Ethical concerns:
  - Platforms often become monopolies as it is hard for competitors to get users to change platform. Leads to reduced consumer choice.
  - Platform owner may favour its own products and services over those of competitors.
  - Extensive collection of user data may breach privacy and risk data breaches.
  - Algorithmic decision-making (e.g., recommendations, account suspension, credit decisions and content moderation) can be opaque, biased and lack accountability mechanisms.
  - ”Gig economy” platforms such as Airbnb, Uber and DoorDash treat gig workers as independent contractors. They lack guarantees of work, minimum wage protection, sick leave and superannuation contributions but must provide their own capital (cars, apartments, etc.). They are often managed by algorithms that rate them poorly if an unsafe pace of work is not maintained. Other providers that were paying commercial rates to cities are displaced.

Enshittification

An emergent business strategy affecting digital platforms.

1) Prioritise users. Attract users by providing a great product.

2) Prioritise business partners at the expense of users.

3) Extract value for shareholders by increasing fees and degrading service.

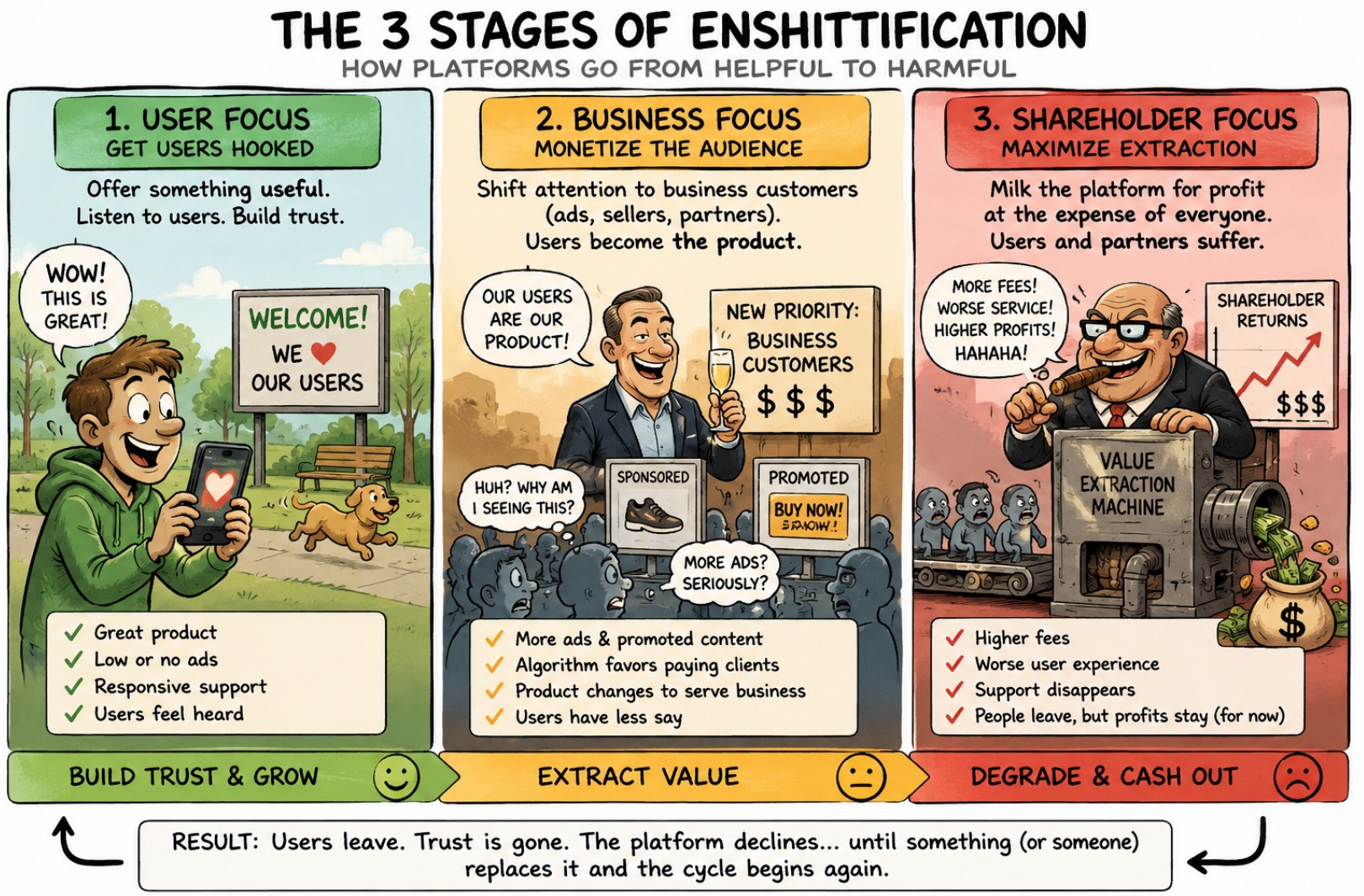


Image generated by ChatGPT

Enshittification (continued)

- Example: Google search
  - 1996: Service launched with no advertisements.
  - 2000: Advertisements added.
  - March 2019: Changes to improve search quality were reversed, allegedly to keep users searching for longer (and seeing more ads). https://www.wheresyoured.at/the-men-who-killed-google/
  - May 2019: Advertisement labels made less noticeable. Now harder to distinguish from real search results.
  - 2023-2024: AI-generated overviews of search results introduced: taking page views and therefore money away from the providers of web sites.
  - 2024: "researchers found …. that the number of spam sites and content mill sites in search results had increased dramatically and that sites that were 'more optimized' for SEO [search engine optimisation], engaged in 'affiliate marketing' and featured 'lower-quality' text were consistently ranking better than higher-quality sites". https://knowyourmeme.com/memes/events/google-search-enshittification

For a laugh, see https://thisecommercelife.com/blogs/comics/005-chickens-figure-out-enshittification and https://www.yahoo.com/lifestyle/articles/57-infuriating-examples-enshittification-prove-143102745.html (but only examples that involve *platforms* meet the original definition of enshittification by Cory Doctorow)

Enshittification (continued)

- **Ethical concerns**: exploiting users' dependence on the platform rather than building trust and loyalty; creates a relationship (in the user's mind) that is later broken; manipulation of autonomy, e.g. making it hard to unsubscribe; abuse of market power if users have limited alternatives; unfair treatment of business partners as platform fees and policies change.
- Doctorow claims that:

  "... the main job of a CEO is to show up for work every morning and yank on the enshittification lever as hard as you can ... **We get good digital services when the enshittification lever doesn't budge — when it is constrained**: by competition, by regulation, by interoperable mods and hacks that undo enshittification (like alternative clients and ad-blockers) and by **workers who have bargaining power thanks to a tight labor market or a powerful union**".

  https://doctorow.medium.com/the-specific-process-by-which-google-enshittified-its-search-1ffd3b02d205

Subscription rather than ownership

- You used to buy and therefore *own* software. Now you mostly *subscribe* to software-as-a-service (SAAS).
- Businesses claim there are many benefits for you. https://www.linkedin.com/pulse/from-ownership-access-rise-subscription-based-bhanu-pratap-3ujye/
- There are also risks. https://sweettntmagazine.com/you-will-own-nothing-how-subscriptions-replaced-ownership/
  - Service discontinuation and loss of access to your data.
  - Company buyouts leading to changed policies.
  - Cultural cost: “cultural cost. Physical ownership allows preservation, sharing and inheritance. Digital licensing restricts these practices, limiting how knowledge and media are transmitted across generations”.
  - Unnoticed addiction. https://www.linkedin.com/pulse/trapped-convenience-ethical-dilemmas-nation-grip-k%C5%AFl%C5%9Dh%C5%99%C4%99%C5%9D%C5%A7h%C3%A3--w0mzc/
- Some examples just seem wrong, e.g. buying a car but having to subscribe if you want heated seats or full acceleration that the car is already physically capable of. https://www.bbc.com/news/technology-63743597

Surveillance Advertising and the Attention Economy

Surveillance Advertising

- Collect user data during the use of free services.
- Use that to provide highly targeted advertising (which advertisers pay for).
- Examples: social media, search engines and maps.
- **Ethical concerns**: extensive collection of personal information; manipulation through microtargeting; limited consent; unexpected secondary uses of data.

Attention Economy

- Maximise the user's engagement to increase advertising revenue.
- Examples: social media.
- **Ethical concerns**: addictive interface design leading to mental health impacts; easy spread of misinformation; outrage amplification (angry content drives more engagement); impact on children's wellbeing; prioritisation of content aimed at dominant cultural identities—marginalising other groups.

Takeaway message

Takeaway message



ChatGPT 5.5



Claude Opus 4.6

Takeaway message

For you as a consumer of computing technology:

- Tech workers generally don't understand the needs and preferences of many of their users (see the slide on demographics)
- Big Tech leaders most likely don't share your culture and values.
- They seem focused on dreams of a technology-driven future and current politics rather than their users.

For you as a future tech worker and (perhaps one day) leader:

- Remember that your users' needs, preferences, values and politics may not be the same as yours.
- It's up to you and your colleagues to model and promote ethical and user-focused behaviour (the Broligarchy aren't doing it!).